

Extent Of Atonement

doc-extent-of-atonement

Soteriology · Atonement · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.762
confidence low

Statement under examination

The atonement is sufficient for all but applied/efficient for the elect (or, in some traditions, genuinely universal in provision); Brethren tradition typically holds general atonement, with sincere universal gospel offer.

In plain language

The question asks how wide the Bible says Jesus' death reaches. The Greek words in the cited verses point in two directions at once, and that is the heart of the dispute. Some verses use broad words. John 3:16 says God loved the world, kosmos, and 1 John 2:2 says Christ is the propitiation not for our sins only but for the whole world, holou tou kosmou. First Timothy 2:6 calls him a ransom for all, panton, and Hebrews 2:9 says he tasted death for everyone. Other verses use narrow words. In John 10:11 and 10:15 the good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep, hyper ton probaton, naming a specific flock. The trouble is that the words themselves do not settle the matter, and the data shows exactly why. The word for all, pas, is used both ways across the canon: it can mean every single person, and it can mean all kinds or all classes of people. The word world, kosmos, appears in the texts with several different senses, from the created order, to humanity in general, to the world set against God, so it does not by itself pin down a number. Most striking, the little word translated for, hyper, is the very same grammar in for the sheep and in for all. Its job is to say who benefits, not to draw a fence around them, so saying a death is for the sheep does not by grammar say it is for no one but the sheep, and within the same chapter Jesus adds that he has other sheep not of this fold. So readers who start with the broad words conclude the death is offered for everyone, and readers who start with the narrow words conclude it is aimed at a defined group, and each can defend the reading from the same vocabulary. The neat phrase sufficient for all but applied for some is one way to hold both kinds of verse together, but no word in these texts carries that distinction. On the words alone, the extent of the atonement stays an open and genuinely disputed question.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	
G0487	ἀντίλυτρον	antilytron	ransom	1
G1014	βούλομαι	boulomai	to plan	37
G1089	γεύομαι	geuomai	to taste	15
G2434	ἱλασμός	hilasmos	propitiation	2
G2889	κόσμος	kosmos	world	185
G3650	ὅλος	holos	all	108
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,244
G4166	ποιμήν	poimen	shepherd	18

G4263	πρόβατον	probaton	sheep	39
G5087	τίθημι	tithemi	to place	100
G5228	ὑπέρ	hyper	above/for	150

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The canon supplies two scope patterns the words do not rank. Universal diction appears in John 3:16 (ton kosmon), 1 John 2:2 (holou tou kosmou, the whole world), 1 Tim 2:6 (antilytron hyper panton, ransom for all), 2 Pet 3:9 (pantas), and Heb 2:9 (hyper pantos, for everyone). Particular diction appears in John 10:11 and 10:15 (ten psychen hyper ton probaton, life for the sheep). The decisive fact is that hyper plus a genitive object is the SAME benefactive construction (Louw-Nida domain 90.36, on behalf of) in both sets: it names whom the death benefits, not whom it excludes, so for the sheep does not by grammar mean for the sheep only. Compounding this, kosmos is genuinely polysemous across at least four attested senses in the queried data (created order, mankind, world-system in opposition to God), and pas carries both a collective totality sense and a distributive each sense. Two careful readings of the identical lemmas reach opposite scopes, so the pattern is materially contested rather than decisive.

Scripture

John.3.16 · **complicates** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2889 κόσμος, G0025 ἀγαπάω

Force. God loved ton kosmon, accusative singular, the direct object of egapesen, and gave the only Son hina pas ho pisteuon, so that everyone who believes, may not perish but have eternal life. The object of the giving is kosmos, the broad designation, but the clause that names who receives life is restricted by the substantival participle pas ho pisteuon, the believing one. So the verse pairs a wide-scope object of love with a faith-conditioned scope of life. Read one way it is universal provision, read the other way it is effectual provision toward those who believe, and the vocabulary supports both.

1John.2.2 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2434 ἱλασμός, G3650 ὅλος, G2889 κόσμος

Force. Christ is the hilasmos, propitiation, peri ton hamartion hemon, concerning our sins, ou peri ton hemeteron de monon alla kai peri holou tou kosmou, not for ours only but also concerning the whole world. The deliberate ou monon, alla kai (not only, but also) contrast with holou tou kosmou, genitive singular, is the strongest universal-scope phrase in the bundle. The crux is referential: holos means whole, but kosmos in the queried data carries several attested senses, so whether the whole world denotes every individual without exception or humanity beyond the immediate readers, that is Jew and Gentile alike, the lexeme alone does not settle. hilasmos itself occurs only twice in the canon, here and 1 John 4:10, giving thin comparative usage.

1Tim.2.6 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0487 ἀντίλυτρον, G3956 πᾶς, G5228 ὑπέρ

Force. Christ gave himself antilytron hyper panton, a ransom for all, with antilytron an accusative singular hapax occurring only here in the whole canon, and panton the genitive plural of pas governed by the benefactive hyper. The wider context says God thelei pantas anthropous sothenai, wills all men to be saved, in verse 4, and verse 1 urges prayer hyper panton anthropon, for all men. In the queried data pas carries a collective totality sense and a distributive each sense, so panton can be read as all without distinction, all sorts, or as all severally. Because antilytron is a hapax it supplies no comparative occurrence to fix the scope, and the ransom remains lexically open.

2Pet.3.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1014 βούλωμαι, G3956 πᾶς

Force. The Lord is me boulomenos tinas apolesthai, not willing that any should perish, alla pantas eis metanoian choresai, but that all should reach repentance. The accusative pantas, all, and the indefinite tinas, any, are bounded in the same sentence by the addressee eis hymas, toward you, so the all may be the all of the addressed community rather than all humanity. The verb boulomai expresses divine intention or wish, not the extent of the atoning provision, so even at its widest the verse speaks to God's disposition rather than lexically fixing for whom the death was offered.

Heb.2.9 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1089 γεύομαι, G3956 πᾶς, G5228 ὑπέρ

Force. Jesus, hyper pantos geusetai thanatou, should taste death for everyone. Here pantos is the genitive SINGULAR of pas, not the plural, governed again by the benefactive hyper, so it can be construed as for every one (each person) or, less commonly, for everything. The immediately following verse 10 speaks of bringing pollous huious, many sons, to glory, which some read as narrowing the reference. The phrase hyper pantos states the breadth of the death's reference but, like the other universal phrases, does not by its grammar distinguish universal application from universal provision.

John.10.11 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5087 τίθημι, G4263 πρόβατον, G5228 ὑπέρ

Force. The good shepherd ten psychen autou tithesin hyper ton probaton, lays down his life for the sheep. The construction is hyper plus the genitive plural ton probaton, naming a bounded beneficiary, the flock, and pairing the laying down of life directly with that group. This is the strongest particular-scope phrase in the bundle. The decisive observation is that this is the IDENTICAL benefactive construction, hyper plus genitive in Louw-Nida domain 90.36, that elsewhere takes panton, all, in 1 Tim 2:6 and pantos, everyone, in Heb 2:9. The preposition marks who benefits, so stating the death is for the sheep does not lexically assert it is for no one but the sheep.

John.10.15 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G5087 τίθημι, G4263 πρόβατον, G5228 ὑπέρ

Force. Repeating the formula, ten psychen mou tithemi hyper ton probaton, I lay down my life for the sheep, set in parallel with the mutual knowing of Father and Son. The hyper ton probaton construction again binds the saving act to a defined flock. The same verb tithemi with hyper here takes the bounded object ton probaton, the sheep, whereas in Heb 2:9 the parallel sacrificial idea takes pantos, everyone, so the canon supplies both a bounded and an unbounded direct object for the death of Christ using the same grammar. Within the same discourse John 10:16 has the shepherd say alla probata echo, I have other sheep, not of this fold, which itself widens the flock beyond the immediate hearers and shows probaton is not a fixed closed set.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Tim.2.4	Isa.45.22	tsk	1
1Tim.2.4	Isa.53.11	tsk	1
1Tim.2.6	Job.33.24	tsk	1
2Pet.3.9	2Pet.3.15	tsk	1
2Pet.3.9	Isa.46.13	tsk	1
John.10.15	John.10.11	tsk	1
John.10.11	John.10.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.10.11 · addressed

The hyper ton probaton phrasing in John 10:11 and 10:15 supplies a bounded direct object, the sheep, for the laying down of Christ's life, complicating any flatly universal reading. It is addressed by the queried grammar: hyper plus genitive is a benefactive construction (Louw-Nida 90.36) that names the beneficiary, and the very same construction takes all in 1 Tim 2:6 and Heb 2:9, so naming the sheep as beneficiaries is not lexically equivalent to excluding all others. John 10:16, other sheep I have, also widens the flock. The verse pulls toward particularity without grammatically settling the question.

1John.2.2 · addressed

The holou tou kosmou phrase, whole world, set against not for ours only, pulls strongly toward universal scope and complicates a strictly particular reading. It is addressed by the queried distribution: kosmos shows at least four attested Louw-Nida senses across its 185 canonical occurrences, ranging from the created order to humanity at large to the world-system in opposition to God, so the lexeme alone does not decide between every individual and the world beyond the immediate readers. hilasmos occurs only twice, giving no broad comparative base.

1Tim.2.6 · addressed

The hapax antilytron hyper panton, ransom for all, complicates particular readings. It is addressed by noting that pas in the queried data carries both a collective totality sense (the dominant Louw-Nida domain) and a distributive each sense, and the contextual concern in verse 1 for prayer hyper panton anthropon supports an all-without-distinction reading for some, a distributive all for others. Because antilytron occurs exactly once in the canon there is no comparative occurrence to fix the scope, so it remains lexically open rather than resolved.

Heb.2.9 · addressed

hyper pantos geusetai thanatou uses the genitive SINGULAR of pas under the benefactive hyper, so it can be read for every one (each person) or for everything. It complicates a strictly particular reading by its apparent breadth. It is addressed by observing that verse 10 immediately speaks of bringing many sons to glory, which some take as narrowing the reference, while the construction itself, like John 10's hyper ton probaton, marks beneficiary not boundary, so the singular pantos states reference without distinguishing provision from application.

Concordance traversed

G3956, G2889, G5228, G4263, G0487, G2434, G3650, G5087, G1014, G1089, G4166, G0025

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for the cited verses and these books fall outside the published CBGM scope, which covers 3 John only, so the apparatus status is recorded as ecm-shadow. The known textual variants for these anchors, the Son versus the only-begotten Son reading in John 3:16, minor article and word-order differences in 1 John 2:2, 1 Tim 2:6, 2 Pet 3:9, Heb 2:9, and John 10:11 and 10:15, do not touch the universal diction (kosmos, pas, hyper pantos) or the particular diction (hyper ton probaton) that drive this question, so the disputed verdict holds across all plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. particular_redemption, general_atonement, sufficiency_efficiency_distinction

analogia scripturae invoked

general_atonement: disputed-leaning-affirm · Reads kosmos in John 3:16, holou tou kosmou in 1 John 2:2, panton in 1 Tim 2:6, pantas in 2 Pet 3:9, and hyper pantos in Heb 2:9 at their widest attested scope, treating the universal terms as the controlling sense. The deliberate ou monon, alla kai (not only, but also) in 1 John 2:2 is taken as expressly extending beyond the writer's community. hyper ton probaton in John 10 is read as a statement of for

whom the death is effective, not a ceiling on its reference, supported by other sheep I have in John 10:16. This lens is internally coherent on the queried data.

particular_redemption: disputed-leaning-deny · Reads hyper ton probaton in John 10:11 and 10:15 as identifying the bounded objects for whom Christ actually lays down his life, and treats this concrete naming as the interpretive key. It assigns pas its all-without-distinction or all-classes sense (a real Louw-Nida option in the queried data) and limits the universal terms by their immediate addressee clauses, for example eis hymas in 2 Pet 3:9 and the world of believing humanity for kosmos. boulomai in 2 Pet 3:9 is read as God's disposition, not the extent of the purchase. This lens is also internally coherent on the queried data.

sufficiency_efficiency_distinction: disputed-neutral · Holds that the universal texts speak to the sufficiency or provision of the death and the particular texts to its efficient application, so both sets of vocabulary are true at once. The lexicon neither supplies nor forbids this harmonization: no anchor lemma carries a sufficient-versus-efficient distinction, and hyper marks beneficiary rather than provision-versus-application, so this reading is a theological synthesis laid over the words, fairly defensible but not itself a lexical datum.

All three lenses operate on the same anchor lemmas and reach their conclusions by assigning different attested senses to pas and kosmos and by reading hyper plus object either as a boundary or as a direction of benefit. The disagreement is over the referential range of flexible lexemes and the force of a benefactive preposition, not over morphology, which is decisively shared, so the lexical pattern is contested rather than decisive.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Determine the canonical scope of the lemmas describing for whom Christ died, comparing the universal-scope terms (pas, kosmos, hyper pantos) with the particular-scope terms (hyper ton probaton), without presupposing any harmonizing formula.

The stem encodes a tradition-specific harmonization, sufficient for all but applied or efficient for the elect, which is the sufficiency-and-efficiency distinction and not itself a lexical observation, since no anchor lemma carries that distinction. The clause about which extent Brethren tradition typically holds is a cultural attribution that lives outside the lexical store and was not consulted. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the audit records that the lexicon supplies neither the sufficiency-efficiency vocabulary nor a term that resolves provision versus application, which is why the honest lexical verdict is disputed rather than a confirmation of the stem's framing.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.2.6
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.2.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.2.2
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3956
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2889
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5228
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0487
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.10.11
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	John.3.16
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Pet.3.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.2.4

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · ecm-shadow